

Attwater 1958

A Catholic Dictionary — “Dogma” and “Dogmatic Fact” (ed. Donald Attwater, 3rd ed., 1958)

edited by Donald Attwater; third edition, New York: The Macmillan Company, 1958

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- Text transcribed from the Internet Archive scan, p. 154.
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Note on this selection: the shortest witness in this repository, and for that reason among the most telling — a general-reference lexicon for educated Catholics, compressing the dogmatic-fact doctrine into two sentences whose second example is precisely the reigning pope’s legitimacy: “Pius XII is the legitimate successor of St. Peter in the primacy.” The final sentence states the guarantee without qualification: “Concerning such facts the Church is infallible in her judgements.” The adjacent “Dogma” entry is included for context; its closing caution — a dogma “is not assumed to be true because many believe it” — makes a useful foil: the acceptance-argument documented throughout this repository never rests on the number of believers as such, but on the Church’s guaranteed public act of receiving her head (cf. the 1861 Gridel and 1933 Boulenger entries for the same doctrine in the popular literature, and the 1907 Catholic Encyclopedia entry for the fuller article this notice abbreviates).

p. 154 — Dogma

DOGMA (Gr., ordinance). A truth directly proposed by the Church for our belief as an article of divine revelation. The vulgar notion of a dogma, as an arbitrary doctrine imposed nobody quite knows why, is thus seen to be at fault; the content of a dogma is truth revealed by God and therefore must be believed; it is not assumed to be true because many believe it.

p. 154 — Dogmatic Fact

DOGMATIC FACT. A truth, not revealed, but so intimately connected with revelation that it cannot be denied without imperilling some dogma, e.g., our Scriptures are genuine; **Pius XII is the legitimate successor of St. Peter in the primacy.** Concerning such facts the Church is infallible in her judgements.